

SEASON ONE

FILTHY RICH

THE PERFORMANCE



LIFE

TABLE: YOU

AMBITION	0.00
IMAGE	0.00
STATUS	0.00
ATTENTION	0.00
VALIDATION	0.00
PEACE	????

TOTAL PRICELESS*



THANK YOU
COME BACK TOMORROW

TOO GLAMOROUS
TO CHECK THE BALANCE.

FR

A SERIES BY
REIRA BIN

SEASON ONE

FILTHY RICH

THE PERFORMANCE

Too glamorous to check the balance.

A SERIES BY REIRA BIN

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Financially Delusional

Daniel had never missed a payment.

He had postponed several.

There was a difference.

At least, there was when he explained it.

The new credit card arrived on a Tuesday morning in a black box with silver lettering and a piece of paper congratulating him on being selected.

Daniel read the word selected twice.

He had applied online three weeks earlier.

Still, selection was selection.

The card was metal.

It made a satisfying sound when he placed it on the kitchen counter.

A serious sound.

The kind of sound money made when it no longer needed to explain itself.

Daniel turned it over in his hand.

Zero percent interest for twelve months.

Double reward points on travel, dining and professional expenses.

A credit limit high enough to feel like trust.

“It’s not debt,” he said.

The apartment was empty.

“It’s runway.”

He said it again.

The second version sounded more responsible.

Daniel worked in marketing for a software company.

He was good at it.

He understood attention, positioning and the quiet power of presenting an unfinished thing as if everyone else had arrived late.

His salary was respectable.

His expenses were ambitious.

For the past eighteen months, Daniel had been building what he called his personal brand.

The brand had not yet produced income.

It had produced a logo.

The first thing he bought with the new card was a chair.

It cost twelve hundred dollars.

The chair was Italian, although Daniel could not remember which part of Italy had designed it.

It was low, cream and uncomfortable in a way that suggested confidence.

He placed it behind his desk, exactly where it would appear during video calls.

Clients trusted people who had considered their chairs.

“You already have a chair,” his sister Maya said when she visited that evening.

“That’s a dining chair.”

“You sit on it.”

“That’s not the same thing.”

Maya looked at the new chair.

“Is this one better for sitting?”

“It’s not really about sitting.”

Daniel adjusted the angle.

The chair looked more expensive when it faced slightly away from the light.

“It’s part of the environment.”

“What environment?”

“The one I’m building.”

Maya looked around.

The apartment had one lamp, no curtains and three unopened boxes marked
ESSENTIAL BRAND EQUIPMENT.

“What exactly are you building?”

Daniel smiled.

“Trust.”

The chair appeared in his next video call.

Nobody mentioned it.

Daniel considered this a success.

Premium things were not supposed to ask for attention.

They were supposed to be noticed subconsciously.

That Friday, he ordered a new camera.

His laptop camera worked perfectly.

That was not the point.

The new one produced cinematic depth.

Daniel had watched six reviews.

One reviewer had used the phrase executive presence.

The camera cost nine hundred dollars.

The lens cost another four hundred.

The lighting kit was on sale.

Not buying it would have been wasteful.

When Maya called again, Daniel was sitting between two softbox lights in a T-shirt he had changed three times.

“You look like you’re being interviewed about a crime,” she said.

“It’s a test setup.”

“For what?”

“Content.”

“What content?”

Daniel looked at the camera.

“That’s still evolving.”

Over the next month, Daniel upgraded quietly.

A microphone because bad sound damaged credibility.

A watch because people noticed wrists during hand gestures.

A coffee machine because morning-routine content performed well.

A leather notebook because writing ideas into his phone looked distracted.

Each purchase had a purpose.

Each purpose had a sentence.

Daniel rarely bought anything until he could explain why it was necessary.

The explanations usually arrived before the money did.

At work, Daniel gave excellent advice.

He told junior colleagues to avoid lifestyle inflation.

He told one of them not to finance a car just because the monthly payment looked manageable.

“Monthly payments hide the real cost,” Daniel said.

The junior colleague nodded and wrote it down.

Daniel liked being written down.

At lunch, a coworker named Leah asked him how he managed money so confidently.

“I think long-term,” he said.

He did.

Usually about how things would look six months from now.

That afternoon, Daniel received an email inviting him to a private industry dinner.

The event was not private.

It had a website.

But the restaurant was expensive, the guest list included two people with large online followings, and the invitation used his first name.

Daniel read it three times.

The dress code was Elevated Business Casual.

His current wardrobe was business casual.

There was no elevation.

At six, he entered a menswear store.

A salesperson approached him.

“Looking for anything specific?”

“Something understated.”

The salesperson nodded.

“Of course.”

Daniel tried on a charcoal suit.

It fit perfectly.

This concerned him.

Perfect things were rarely affordable.

“How much?” he asked.

The salesperson told him.

Daniel kept looking at himself in the mirror.

The suit changed his posture.

It made his apartment seem temporary.

“It’s an investment piece,” the salesperson said.

Daniel smiled.

He appreciated professional language.

He paid with the metal card.

The sound was excellent.

At home, Maya was sitting at the kitchen counter when he arrived.

She looked at the garment bag.

“What did you buy?”

“A suit.”

“You own suits.”

“Not for this room.”

“What room?”

“The room I’m moving into.”

Maya looked at him.

“Do you mean a restaurant?”

Daniel placed the garment bag carefully over the new chair.

“It’s about positioning.”

“How much was it?”

“That’s not the useful question.”

“It’s the first useful question.”

Daniel opened the refrigerator.

There was mustard, sparkling water and half a lemon.

He closed it.

“The suit will pay for itself.”

“How?”

“Access.”

“To food?”

“To opportunity.”

Maya watched him place a delivery order on his phone.

His card was declined.

Daniel frowned.

He tried again.

Declined.

Maya said nothing.

Daniel switched cards.

The payment went through.

“Bank issue,” he said.

“Of course.”

The dinner took place on Friday.

Daniel arrived twelve minutes late.

Not because he was delayed.

Because arriving first looked eager.

The restaurant was dark, polished and designed to make every table feel unavailable.

Daniel handed his coat to the host.

The suit performed beautifully.

At the table, he spoke about brand equity, long-term value and the danger of confusing visibility with credibility.

People listened.

One of the influencers asked for his opinion on a campaign.

Daniel gave a good answer.

A genuinely good one.

For twenty minutes, the future looked close enough to invoice.

Then the bill arrived.

The group had ordered freely.

Daniel had ordered carefully.

This did not matter.

Someone suggested splitting the total evenly.

Everyone agreed quickly.

Daniel looked at the number.

It was not impossible.

It was simply located in a different version of the week.

He placed the metal card on the tray.

It made the same serious sound.

The waiter returned two minutes later.

“There seems to be an issue with this one.”

The table remained quiet for half a second.

Daniel smiled.

“Fraud protection.”

He took out another card.

The second card worked.

Barely.

The conversation moved on.

Nobody appeared to notice.

Daniel noticed everyone not noticing.

Outside the restaurant, one of the influencers shook his hand.

“Great meeting you,” he said. “You’re clearly doing very well.”

Daniel smiled.

“Building.”

The word was useful.

It could mean progress.

It could mean unfinished.

It could mean there were still walls missing.

On the ride home, Daniel opened his banking app.

The balance loaded slowly.

He turned down the brightness.

The suit lay beside him in the back seat, still holding the shape of the evening.

Three card payments were due before payday.

The rent was due Monday.

The camera had not earned anything.

The chair had not earned anything.

The dinner had produced two new contacts, one follow request and a photograph in which Daniel looked exactly like the person he planned to become.

He opened the photograph.

It was good.

Better than good.

He looked established.

Calm.

Expensive in a quiet way.

Daniel posted it.

Always grateful to be in rooms where the conversation is bigger than the table.

He watched the first likes arrive.

At home, Daniel hung the suit carefully outside the wardrobe.

The wardrobe was too full.

He sat in the Italian chair.

It remained uncomfortable.

His phone displayed a notification.

Payment due in 3 days.

Daniel dismissed it.

Three days was plenty of time.

By then, he planned to be someone else.

Business Class

Maya arrived at the airport four hours early.

Her flight was at six.

Her content started at two.

She wore a beige coat, oversized sunglasses and shoes that had been designed for photographs rather than distance.

Her suitcase rolled quietly behind her.

It was mostly empty.

The credit card used to buy it was not.

At the entrance to the business lounge, Maya stopped beside a gold sign.

She placed her passport over the boarding pass.

Economy Class faced down.

She took fourteen photographs.

In one, she held a coffee.

In another, she looked away from the camera as though someone important had just called her name.

Nobody had.

A family walked around her and entered the lounge.

Maya waited for the doors to close.

Then she posted the photograph.

Airport mornings.

Somewhere between ambition and altitude.

She added the location.

Business Lounge.

Technically, she was beside it.

Her friend Chloe replied almost immediately.

Business class again??

Maya typed:

You know me :D

She deleted it.

Then wrote:

I've learned to invest in comfort.

That sounded more expensive.

At 3:15, Maya bought a coffee from the kiosk opposite the lounge.

It cost nine dollars.

She photographed it before drinking.

The foam collapsed while she adjusted the brightness.

At 3:42, she entered a luxury store.

She picked up a handbag and turned slowly toward the mirror.

A sales assistant approached.

"Would you like to try it on?"

"I'm deciding," Maya said.

She held the bag at waist height and took three photographs.

The assistant waited.

Maya checked the pictures.

"Do you mind taking one?"

The assistant took the phone.

Maya turned slightly.

Not too much.

The label needed to remain visible.

“Perfect,” Maya said.

She returned the bag.

“Still deciding?”

“Always.”

The assistant nodded.

She had met ambition before.

Maya posted the photograph.

Tempted.

At 4:20, she recorded herself walking past the departure boards.

She filmed the business-class check-in area.

Then the first-class entrance.

Then herself.

The video stopped before the economy queue appeared.

At 5:05, her flight moved to Gate 47.

It was a twenty-minute walk.

Maya looked down at her shoes.

They had already begun to disagree with the journey.

At the gate, passengers formed several lines.

Maya stood near Priority Boarding.

Not inside it.

Near it.

She raised her phone and recorded the sign.

PRIORITY

The video ended before Group 6 was called.

When boarding began, Maya waited.

Group 1.

Group 2.

Group 3.

She continued scrolling.

Group 4.

Group 5.

Maya stood before anyone announced Group 6.

She preferred to look ready.

On the plane, she found seat 38B.

Middle seat.

A man was already sitting by the window.

A woman entered behind her carrying a baby.

Maya stepped aside.

The woman placed the baby in the aisle seat.

Maya smiled.

“Would either of you prefer the middle?”

The man looked out of the window.

The woman adjusted the baby.

Maya sat down.

Her coat rested across her knees.

Her handbag remained upright between her feet.

There was no room for the version of her that had arrived at the airport.

Before takeoff, Maya opened Instagram.

The lounge photograph had 312 likes.

Chloe had commented:

The lifestyle <3

Another friend wrote:

Teach me your ways.

Maya smiled.

The baby began to cry.

She turned up the brightness on her phone.

The flight attendant announced that onboard Wi-Fi cost eighteen dollars.

Maya locked the screen.

“I don’t really use Wi-Fi when I travel,” she said.

Nobody had asked.

During the flight, the woman beside her fell asleep on Maya’s shoulder.

The baby kicked her handbag.

The man by the window asked to use the bathroom three times.

Maya kept her shoes on.

Removing them would have meant accepting what they had done to her feet.

Two hours later, the plane landed.

Passengers stood immediately.

Maya remained seated.

She said she preferred to avoid the rush.

The truth was that her left shoe had become difficult to negotiate with.

When the cabin emptied, she stood in the aisle.

Empty seats.
Soft morning light.
No baby.
No middle seat.
No evidence.
She took one final photograph.
Then another.
Then one with the sunglasses.
She posted it before reaching baggage claim.
There's nothing like travelling well.
At the carousel, her suitcase did not arrive.
Maya waited beside a family from her flight.
The baby was asleep.
The mother looked rested.
Maya checked the airline app.
Her luggage had been delayed.
Her credit card payment was due the next morning.
Her feet hurt.
Her coffee was still visible in the first photograph.
Chloe sent another message.
You make it look effortless.
Maya looked at the carousel.
Then at the message.
She typed:
It really is.

The carousel continued without her suitcase.

Couple Goals

Olivia never posted photographs immediately.

Happiness looked more expensive after careful editing.

She and Ethan had been together for four years.

Instagram had celebrated at least six.

Every anniversary arrived with a professionally written caption.

Every holiday came with a sunset.

Every argument waited.

On Friday evening, they booked a table at the city's newest restaurant.

Reservations were difficult.

Which meant people wanted to know you had one.

Olivia chose the table nearest the window.

Natural light forgave almost everything.

Ethan picked up the menu.

Olivia picked up her phone.

"Don't touch it yet," she said.

"The food?"

"The evening."

The waiter arrived.

"Would you like sparkling or still?"

Olivia smiled.

“Whichever photographs better.”

The waiter looked at the bottles.

“Sparkling,” he said.

The drinks arrived first.

Olivia moved Ethan’s glass three times.

She turned the candle slightly.

She asked him to lean closer.

“Not that close.”

He moved back.

“Perfect.”

Ethan watched her take twelve photographs.

“You can drink now,” she said.

“I wasn’t thirsty anymore.”

The food arrived.

Nobody touched it.

Olivia stood up.

“Just one overhead shot.”

The waiter walked around her.

Another couple waited while she photographed the pasta from three different angles.

By the time they started eating, the food was warm instead of hot.

“It still tastes good,” Ethan said.

Olivia looked at the photograph.

“It looked better before.”

Halfway through dinner, she posted it.

My favorite place.
Two red hearts.
Grateful for this life. <3
The comments appeared within seconds.
Couple goals.
You two are perfect.
Manifesting this.
Olivia smiled.
Ethan watched her smile.
“Do you still want me here?” he asked.
She looked up.
“Of course.”
“You haven’t looked at me all evening.”
“I’m looking at you now.”
Her phone vibrated.
She turned it over.
“Sorry. I just want to reply while it’s fresh.”
Ethan nodded.
The waiter returned.
“Everything okay?”
“Perfect,” Olivia said.
Ethan looked at the untouched side of his plate.
“It’s good.”
The waiter collected the dishes.
Olivia ordered dessert.

Neither of them wanted dessert.

The lighting had improved.

Outside the restaurant, Ethan stopped walking.

Olivia continued scrolling.

“When were you going to put it away?” he asked.

She looked up.

“I have now.”

The phone was still in her hand.

“Olivia.”

“What?”

He looked at her for a moment.

“Nothing.”

They walked towards the car in silence.

Before getting in, Olivia stopped beneath a streetlight.

“The light is beautiful.”

She lifted her phone.

Ethan stood beside her.

He smiled automatically.

Years of practice.

The photograph was perfect.

In the car, Olivia began choosing a filter.

Ethan drove without speaking.

“When are you posting that one?” he asked.

“Tomorrow morning.”

He kept his eyes on the road.

“And when are we telling people?”

Olivia looked at the photograph.

“Not tomorrow.”

At home, Ethan opened the trunk.

His suitcase was still inside.

Olivia’s phone vibrated.

You two give me hope.

She liked the comment.

Online, they were still having dinner.

Minimalist

Claire owned eleven books about owning fewer things.

They were arranged by color.

The white ones sat on the top shelf because they looked calmer.

Claire had discovered minimalism during a stressful month in which three packages arrived on the same day.

She took this as a sign.

By Sunday, she had watched two documentaries, followed six minimalist creators and ordered a linen storage system from Denmark.

The storage system had fourteen compartments.

Claire called this simplifying.

Her apartment was already tidy.

It became expensive to look empty.

She replaced the colorful cushions with beige ones.

Then replaced the beige ones with slightly warmer beige ones.

The first set went into a storage box under the bed.

The second set went into another storage box because they felt too yellow in photographs.

Her friend Naomi visited one afternoon.

The apartment smelled faintly of cedar and financial commitment.

“It looks peaceful,” Naomi said.

Claire smiled.

“That’s the whole point.”

Naomi looked around.

“Where is everything?”

“Hidden.”

“Isn’t minimalism about having less?”

Claire opened a cabinet.

Inside were five labeled baskets.

CABLES

SPARE CABLES

CABLES TO REVIEW

CHARGERS

OLD CHARGERS

“It’s about visual clarity,” Claire said.

Naomi picked up a small ceramic object from the coffee table.

“What is this?”

“A hand-thrown incense holder.”

“Do you burn incense?”

“No.”

Naomi put it back.

Claire had bought it because the empty table looked unfinished.

The table had cost eight hundred dollars.

It was made from reclaimed wood.

Every object in the apartment had a story.

Most had tracking numbers.

On Tuesday, Claire posted a photograph of the living room.

White wall.

Beige sofa.

Single branch in a glass vase.

No cables.

No baskets.

No evidence.

Her caption read:

Less, but better.

People responded immediately.

So calming.

Teach me your ways.

I need this energy.

Claire saved every comment.

That evening, she watched a video titled Ten Things Minimalists Never Buy.

She already owned eight of them.

The ninth was a label maker.

She ordered one before the video ended.

The next weekend, Claire decided to declutter.

She created three piles:

Keep.

Donate.

Sell.

Everything entered the keep pile first.

The linen storage system had been expensive.

The cushions might work in winter.

The books were part of her journey.

The unused incense holder was handmade.

The coffee machine brought intentionality to mornings.

The second coffee machine was for guests.

The third had been discontinued.

By midnight, she had donated one mug.

It had a logo on it.

Claire felt lighter.

She posted a photograph of the empty kitchen counter.

Making space for what matters.

Behind the camera, the dining table held everything she had moved out of frame.

Naomi called the next morning.

“How did the decluttering go?”

“Really well.”

“What did you get rid of?”

“A mug.”

There was a pause.

Claire looked at the mug in the donation bag.

It was still in the apartment.

“I’m being intentional,” she added.

“About the mug?”

“About the process.”

After the call, Claire opened a minimalist homeware website.

The homepage showed a white room with almost nothing in it.

Claire looked around her apartment.

She did not want the room.

She wanted the feeling.

The room contained a chair.

Claire clicked on it.

The chair cost eleven hundred dollars.

There was a waiting list.

She joined immediately.

By the end of the month, Claire owned fewer visible things than ever.

The bedroom door no longer opened all the way.

EPISODE 05

The Perfect Proposal

Noah had planned the proposal for eleven months.

He had planned the marriage for almost none.

The ring came first.

Then the photographer.

Then the location.

Then the backup location.

Then the weather contingency.

Then the second photographer, because the first one specialized in emotion but not architecture.

By February, Noah had a spreadsheet.

It had six tabs.

TIMELINE

VENDORS

LIGHTING

HER REACTION

SOCIAL MEDIA

CONTINGENCY

His girlfriend, Ava, thought they were going away for the weekend.

Technically, they were.

The proposal happened to be coming with them.

Three weeks before the trip, Noah met with the photographer.

“What kind of reaction are you expecting?” she asked.

“Natural.”

“Of course.”

“But visible.”

She nodded.

“Do you think she’ll cry?”

“Yes.”

“How much?”

Noah hesitated.

“Enough.”

The photographer had heard worse.

Noah chose a cliffside hotel because Ava had once saved a photograph of it.

The room cost more than the ring insurance.

He called the hotel five times.

The flowers had to be white.

The candles had to be unscented.

The champagne label had to face the camera.

Ava did not drink champagne.

That was not the point.

On the morning of the proposal, Noah woke at 5:40.

The light was wrong.

Cloudy.

Flat.

Uncommitted.

He checked three weather apps.
One promised sun.
The other two lacked vision.
At breakfast, Ava reached for a croissant.
“Maybe not that one,” Noah said.
She looked at him.
“Why?”
“Powdered sugar.”
“So?”
“Nothing.”
He smiled.
“Wear whatever you want tonight.”
Ava stopped chewing.
“You already told me that twice.”
“I just want you to feel good.”
“I do.”
“In the blue dress?”
She looked at him for several seconds.
“The blue dress.”
“Only if you want.”
“I didn’t.”
Noah laughed.
Too quickly.
At 4:15, the florist texted.
Running fifteen minutes late.

Noah's pulse increased.

He called immediately.

"I understand," he said, not understanding. "But sunset doesn't."

At 5:02, the photographer sent a picture from behind a stone wall.

In position.

At 5:10, the second photographer sent the same message from a different stone wall.

Noah checked the ring.

Then the sky.

Then Ava.

She was still getting ready.

"Take your time," he called.

He did not mean it.

At 5:26, Ava came outside wearing the blue dress.

Noah stared.

"You look perfect."

She smiled.

"You look terrified."

"I'm not."

"You've checked your watch nine times."

"It's part of the surprise."

Ava stopped walking.

"What surprise?"

Noah froze.

Then smiled.

“The dinner.”

She looked toward the terrace.

There was no dinner.

There were flowers.

Candles.

Two hidden photographers.

One visible drone.

A violinist standing beside a speaker.

Ava looked at Noah.

“Oh.”

He took her hand.

The photographer began shooting.

Noah guided her to the exact center of the terrace.

A small white mark on the floor helped.

Ava looked down.

“What’s that?”

“Nothing.”

The violinist began playing.

It was their song.

Or close to it.

Noah knelt.

Ava covered her mouth.

The first photographer moved left.

The second moved right.

The drone lowered slightly.

Noah opened the ring box.

“Ava,” he began.

Then paused.

The photographer had asked him to.

Ava looked at him.

Wind moved her hair across her face.

The first photographer gestured.

Noah waited.

Ava moved the hair.

He started again.

“Ava, from the moment I met you - ”

The drone came closer.

The violinist missed a note.

Noah glanced sideways.

Ava noticed.

“Are you okay?” she whispered.

“Yes.”

He looked at the camera.

Then back at her.

“From the moment I met you, I knew - ”

A candle went out.

Noah stopped.

The photographer kept shooting.

Ava looked around.

“Do you need to restart?”

“No.”

He laughed.

The laugh sounded expensive and frightened.

He continued.

“You are my best friend. My person. My future.”

Ava’s eyes filled.

Noah saw it.

Good.

He lifted the ring.

“Will you marry me?”

Ava looked at him.

Then at the ring.

Then at the people hiding badly behind the walls.

“Yes.”

Noah exhaled.

The photographers moved closer.

He placed the ring on the wrong finger.

Ava corrected him quietly.

They kissed.

The drone circled.

The violinist finished.

The hotel staff appeared with champagne.

Noah turned the bottle so the label faced outward.

Ava noticed that too.

For the next forty minutes, they reenacted the proposal.

Once from the side.
Once with the sunset behind them.
Once without the drone.
Once with Ava crying again.
She could not.
The photographer suggested laughing instead.
They laughed.
The photographs were beautiful.
At dinner, Ava kept looking at the ring.
Noah kept looking at the previews.
“This one,” he said. “This is the one.”
Ava leaned over.
In the photograph, they looked alone.
The photographers were gone.
The staff were gone.
The drone was gone.
The white mark on the floor was gone.
Even the wind looked intentional.
Ava smiled.
“It’s beautiful.”
Noah zoomed in.
“My jacket is pulling.”
“Noah.”
“I should have stood straighter.”
“Noah.”

He looked up.

She held his gaze.

“Do you remember what I said?”

“Of course.”

“What did I say?”

He lowered the phone.

The waiter arrived.

“Congratulations,” she said.

Ava smiled.

“Thank you.”

Noah smiled too.

The phone vibrated.

The photographer had sent another preview.

He turned it face down.

For almost a minute.

The post went live the next morning.

Black-and-white first image.

Color carousel.

Close-up of the ring.

The caption had been drafted three weeks earlier.

The easiest yes.

Within an hour, thousands of people had watched the proposal.

They saw the flowers.

The cliff.

The dress.

The ring.

They saw Noah kneel.

They saw Ava cry.

By lunchtime, the photographer had delivered a folder titled FINAL.

Ava opened the calendar on her phone.

“Have you thought about when?”

Noah was reading the comments.

“We don’t need to rush.”

The Corner Table

Marcus did not choose restaurants based on food.

Food could be eaten anywhere.

Tables could not.

The new place on Mercer Street had been open for three weeks and already had a waiting list.

The menu was short.

The lighting was low.

The chairs looked uncomfortable in a deliberate way.

Marcus had called four times.

Each time, the answer had been the same.

“We can offer you 5:30 or 10:45.”

Marcus did not eat dinner at 5:30.

And 10:45 looked desperate.

“What about eight?” he asked.

“We’re fully booked.”

“I only need a table for two.”

“Unfortunately, eight is fully booked.”

“I’m bringing someone important.”

“Of course.”

On Thursday, he called again.

This time, he introduced himself using his full name.

It changed nothing.

On Friday, he sent a direct message to the restaurant's Instagram account.

No reply.

On Saturday morning, he commented on their latest post.

Best room in the city.

He had never been inside.

At noon, the restaurant replied with a white heart.

Marcus took this as movement.

By three, he had found the manager on LinkedIn.

At four, he sent a connection request.

At five, it was accepted.

At five-oh-three, Marcus sent a message.

Love what you're building. Would be great to stop by tonight and support.

The manager replied twenty minutes later.

Thanks so much. We're fully booked tonight, but the bar is first come, first served.

Marcus read the message twice.

The bar was not a table.

But it was inside.

He texted his friend Julian.

Got us into Mercer tonight. 8:30.

Julian replied:

Nice. Dinner?

Marcus typed:

Let's see where the night takes us.

The night took them to the bar.

Every stool was occupied.

Marcus stood near the entrance in a dark jacket he had bought that afternoon.

It was too warm for the weather.

That was not the point.

The host approached.

"Can I help you?"

"We're with the manager."

The host nodded politely.

"Name?"

"Marcus Hale."

She checked the list.

Then checked again.

"He mentioned the bar."

"Exactly."

"The bar is full."

Marcus looked toward the dining room.

There was one empty table in the corner.

"What about that one?"

"It's reserved."

"They're already twenty minutes late."

"We'll hold it for them."

Julian looked away.

Marcus did not.

“We can wait.”

“Of course.”

They stood beside a decorative plant for twenty-five minutes.

Marcus ordered two drinks from a passing server.

The drinks arrived with no place to put them.

Julian held both.

“This is going well,” he said.

“It’s early.”

“It’s nine.”

“That’s early for this crowd.”

The crowd was eating dessert.

Marcus scanned the room.

The corner table remained empty.

Every few minutes, he looked toward it.

The host noticed.

“The reservation is running late,” she said.

Marcus smiled.

“So technically - ”

“No.”

At 9:20, a couple entered.

They looked ordinary.

No visible labels.

No urgency.

The host greeted them by name and led them to the corner table.

Marcus watched them sit down.

“That’s them?” he asked.

Julian took a drink.

“Apparently.”

“They don’t even look like they know where they are.”

“They’re sitting down. That helps.”

Marcus checked his phone.

He opened the restaurant’s location tag.

People were posting photographs of candles, glasses and plates designed around empty space.

Marcus raised his drink.

“Take one.”

Julian looked at him.

“Of what?”

“Me.”

“Standing?”

“It’ll look candid.”

Julian took the phone.

Marcus turned slightly toward the dining room.

“Get the tables in the background.”

“I thought this was candid.”

“It can be both.”

Julian took three photographs.

Marcus checked them.

In the first, the decorative plant covered half his face.

In the second, a waiter looked directly at the camera.

The third was usable.

Marcus cropped the bottom of the image so nobody could see he was standing.

He added the location.

Mercer.

Then the caption:

Some rooms are worth the wait.

Julian read it over his shoulder.

“That part is true.”

Marcus posted it.

Within minutes, the comments began.

Hardest table in town.

You always know the spots.

Invite me next time.

Marcus smiled.

The corner table ordered wine.

At 9:47, the host approached.

“A table just opened near the kitchen.”

Marcus looked at it.

The table was small.

Brightly lit.

Beside the service door.

“We’ll wait for something better.”

Julian stared at him.

“We’ve been standing for over an hour.”

“It’s about the experience.”

“My experience has no chair.”

At ten, Julian left.

Marcus said he understood.

He did not.

At 10:15, the bar finally cleared.

Marcus sat down.

The kitchen was closing.

He ordered fries.

They came in a silver bowl.

He photographed them from above.

The angle hid the empty stool beside him.

By the time Marcus left, the post had reached more people than the evening had.

The next morning, someone asked whether the food had been worth it.

Marcus replied:

It’s not really about the food.

Future Owner

Adrian had never owned a boat.

He preferred to say not yet.

On Saturday morning, he arrived at the marina wearing white trousers, a navy shirt and shoes that had never touched water.

The invitation on his phone said:

PRIVATE VIEWING

It had been sent to twelve thousand people.

Adrian showed it to the woman at reception.

“Welcome back,” she said.

It was his first time there.

“Good to be back.”

She gave him a glass of champagne and a blue wristband.

The wristband said GUEST.

Adrian turned it inward.

Around him, polished boats rested on water that appeared to have been cleaned for the occasion.

He walked slowly.

People with money rarely seemed in a hurry.

At the end of the marina, a yacht broker stood beside a white vessel named Patience.

“Beautiful, isn’t she?” the broker said.

Adrian nodded.

“I’m looking for something understated.”

The yacht had four bedrooms, a cinema and a staircase made of glass.

“Of course,” the broker said.

Adrian stepped aboard.

He had watched three videos about yacht etiquette the night before.

He knew not to call the bedrooms bedrooms.

They were cabins.

The kitchen was a galley.

The bathroom was a head.

The price was still the price.

“Are you familiar with this builder?” the broker asked.

“I’ve been watching them for a while.”

This was true.

He followed them on Instagram.

The broker showed him the main deck.

Adrian ran one hand along the table.

“Teak?”

“European oak.”

“Right.”

He nodded as though confirming a private concern.

The broker opened a sliding door.

The sea appeared all at once.

Adrian stopped.

For a moment, he forgot to look informed.

It was beautiful.

Not expensive beautiful.

Just beautiful.

The broker let him have the moment.

Then Adrian remembered his phone.

“Would you mind?” he asked.

He stood beside the railing.

Not smiling.

Smiling looked excited.

Owners looked accustomed.

The broker took the photograph.

“Maybe one looking out?”

Adrian turned towards the horizon.

He imagined mornings here.

Quiet water.

No emails.

No landlord.

No need to explain where his life was going.

The broker took another photograph.

“That’s perfect,” Adrian said.

He had not seen it yet.

Inside, the broker showed him the primary cabin.

Adrian opened a wardrobe.

Empty.

He liked it immediately.

“How many weeks a year are you planning to use her?” the broker asked.

“I don’t really think in weeks.”

The broker waited.

“I value flexibility.”

“Of course.”

Adrian sat on the edge of the bed.

The broker handed him a brochure.

The price appeared discreetly on the final page.

Adrian had expected a large number.

He had not expected it to contain that many decisions.

“Financing can be arranged,” the broker said.

“I wouldn’t finance.”

“No?”

“I prefer clean ownership.”

The broker looked at Adrian’s shoes.

They were beginning to hurt him.

“Very sensible.”

Adrian closed the brochure.

“For me, the real question is lifestyle compatibility.”

“What does your typical year look like?”

Adrian thought about the office.

The rented apartment.

The bus at 7:40.

The Sunday calls with his mother, during which he said work was going very well.

“I travel.”

“Where?”

“Mostly Europe.”

He had visited three countries.

Two had been for work.

One had been an airport connection.

The broker took out a tablet.

“If you’re seriously considering it, we can arrange a sea trial.”

“I never make emotional decisions.”

“Neither do we.”

Adrian appreciated the lie.

His phone vibrated.

A reminder appeared:

Rent due Monday.

He turned the screen over.

“I’m still comparing options.”

“Which other builders are you considering?”

Adrian named two companies he had discovered the previous evening.

The broker nodded.

Both were more expensive.

A couple stepped onto the yacht.

The woman at reception introduced them quietly.

The broker’s posture changed by less than an inch.

Adrian noticed.

“Take your time with the brochure,” the broker said.

“I’ll be in touch.”

“I look forward to it.”

Adrian left the yacht holding the brochure beneath his arm.

At the end of the marina, he stopped beside the water.

He opened the photograph.

The angle was excellent.

The yacht looked close enough to belong to him.

He posted it.

Some decisions take time.

Within minutes, the comments arrived.

Big moves.

You deserve this.

Captain Adrian!

His mother called.

He let it ring.

She would ask whether he had spoken to the landlord.

Adrian walked towards the road.

The marina shuttle was reserved for owners.

He waited at the bus stop opposite the entrance.

There was nothing humiliating about taking the bus.

He knew that.

Still, he stood behind the yacht brochure when it arrived.

On the journey home, the broker sent him a message.

Lovely meeting you. Let me know if you'd like to discuss next steps.

Adrian typed:

Absolutely. Timing is everything.

He looked at the rent reminder.

Then at the photograph.

His mother called again.

This time, he answered.

"How was your day?" she asked.

Adrian watched the marina disappear behind him.

"Productive."

"Did you speak to your landlord?"

The bus entered a tunnel.

Adrian looked at the photograph one more time.

"Bad signal," he said.

The call remained perfectly clear.

Too Rich to Explain

Lucas had an answer for everything.

Especially when nobody had asked.

He called it perspective.

Other people called it exhausting.

When someone bought a car, Lucas spoke about asset allocation.

When someone ordered dessert, he mentioned delayed gratification.

When someone said they were tired, he explained circadian rhythm.

Nothing remained ordinary for long.

Coffee became ritual.

Walking became optimisation.

Lunch became networking.

Rest became recovery.

Six weeks earlier, Lucas's company had eliminated his position.

Lucas called it a strategic exit.

The strategy had not been his.

Every morning, he left the apartment at eight carrying a leather bag.

The bag contained a notebook, two chargers and the letter confirming his final payment.

It did not contain a laptop.

The laptop had belonged to the company.

Lucas spent his mornings in the lobby of a hotel near his old office.

The coffee was expensive.

The tables were free.

At nine, he opened his notebook.

At nine fifteen, he photographed it.

At nine thirty, he posted:

Building quietly.

Then he checked the jobs page he had already checked at home.

On Tuesday, his former colleague Emma walked through the lobby.

She stopped beside his table.

“Lucas?”

He looked up slowly, as though returning from an important thought.

“Emma. How are things?”

“Busy. You?”

“Expanding.”

She looked at the empty chair opposite him.

“Did you find something?”

“I’m advising.”

This was almost true.

A man he knew had asked for his opinion on a website.

Lucas had sent three paragraphs.

The man had replied with a thumbs-up.

“That’s great,” Emma said. “Who are you working with?”

Lucas smiled.

“I’m being selective.”

The waiter placed the bill beside his coffee.

Lucas turned his notebook over it.

“Of course,” Emma said.

She wished him luck.

Lucas wished her growth.

After she left, he added Consultant to his profile.

The platform asked for a company name.

Lucas entered his own.

It looked better in capital letters.

That afternoon, he joined a video call about a role he wanted.

Behind him stood a bookshelf in the hotel lobby.

He positioned the camera carefully.

The interviewer smiled.

“Your background is impressive.”

“It’s really about the direction of travel.”

“And what have you been doing since March?”

Lucas nodded.

He had prepared for this.

“I’ve been creating space for the right opportunity.”

The interviewer waited.

Lucas continued.

“I’m at a stage where alignment matters more than activity.”

“So you’re currently available?”

“For the right conversation.”

The interviewer made a note.

For the first time that day, Lucas stopped explaining.

On Friday evening, he met his old friend Aaron for coffee.

Aaron had known him before coffee became ritual.

“How have you been?” Aaron asked.

“Focused.”

“On what?”

“The next phase.”

Aaron stirred sugar into his coffee.

Lucas watched but said nothing.

“Did you get the job?” Aaron asked.

Lucas looked towards the window.

“It wasn’t the right fit.”

“Did they offer it?”

“That’s not how I measure fit.”

Aaron put down the spoon.

“Are you okay?”

Lucas smiled.

“I’ve stopped thinking in okay.”

Aaron waited.

Lucas reached for his coffee.

It had gone cold.

When the bill arrived, Aaron paid before Lucas could explain why he should.

Outside, they shook hands.

“You know you can call me,” Aaron said.

“Absolutely.”

“I mean properly.”

Lucas nodded.

“I value that.”

That evening, he photographed the leather bag beside his notebook and a fresh coffee.

The hotel bookshelf appeared softly behind them.

His caption read:

The quiet seasons build the loudest futures.

Hundreds of people agreed.

Aaron sent a message twenty minutes later.

You didn’t answer me earlier. Are you actually okay?

Lucas began typing.

I’m entering a period of intentional -

He deleted it.

Everything is aligning.

He deleted that too.

Lucas had an answer for everything.

He left this one unread.

Old Money

The house had been in Eleanor's family for twenty-seven years.

She preferred to say generations.

Her parents had bought it in 1999.

This was technically the last century.

Eleanor found the phrase useful.

The house stood at the end of a quiet street behind iron gates that no longer opened properly.

The left gate had been stuck since February.

Guests entered through the right and assumed it was tradition.

Inside, the walls held portraits of people nobody in the family could identify.

Eleanor had bought three of them at an estate sale.

"They're ancestors," she told visitors.

Her husband, Richard, had once asked whose.

"Emotionally?" she said.

He stopped asking.

Every December, Eleanor hosted a family lunch.

She called it the annual gathering at the house.

Her brother called it Sunday lunch.

This year, Eleanor had printed menus.

Cream paper.

Gold lettering.

No prices.

The menu read:

WINTER LUNCHEON

At the Ashford Residence

The family name was Bennett.

Ashford was the street.

Eleanor felt some details improved with distance.

Richard found her arranging silverware at eight in the morning.

"We have twelve forks," he said.

"We need eighteen."

"For what?"

"The fish course."

"We're having chicken."

"The table doesn't know that."

Richard looked at the place settings.

There were three forks beside every plate.

"Which one do I use?"

"The outside one first."

"For chicken?"

"For confidence."

The dining room had not been heated.

The boiler was making a noise Eleanor described as seasonal.

Richard described it differently.

"Should we call someone?"

“After lunch.”

“It’s twelve degrees in here.”

“Old houses breathe.”

“This one is coughing.”

Eleanor placed two candles near the window.

They gave the room warmth in photographs.

Her mother arrived first carrying a supermarket dessert.

Eleanor took it from her quickly.

“I made trifle,” her mother said.

“Wonderful.”

“Where should I put it?”

“In the kitchen.”

“Are we not eating it?”

“Of course.”

Eleanor lowered her voice.

“Just not immediately.”

Her mother looked at the printed menus.

“What’s winter consommé?”

“Soup.”

“What soup?”

“Vegetable.”

“From a carton?”

Eleanor smiled.

“Reduced.”

The rest of the family arrived in coats they did not remove.

Eleanor greeted everyone beside the staircase.

The staircase looked best from that angle.

Her nephew pointed at one of the portraits.

“Who’s that?”

“Your great-great-uncle.”

“What was his name?”

Eleanor looked at the painting.

The man wore a military jacket and appeared disappointed in the future.

“Charles.”

Richard walked past carrying glasses.

“You said his name was Edward.”

“Charles Edward.”

Her nephew nodded.

Children accepted history easily when adults used two names.

At lunch, Eleanor stood at the head of the table.

She raised a glass.

“To family.”

Everyone raised theirs.

“To history.”

Her brother looked around.

“What history?”

Eleanor smiled.

“The kind you inherit.”

Richard looked at the mortgage statement beneath a stack of mail.

He moved it out of sight.

The first course arrived.

The reduced vegetable soup had reduced too far.

It was served in small bowls.

This made it look intentional.

Eleanor's sister tasted it.

"Is it meant to be cold?"

"It's a winter soup."

The chicken followed.

Eleanor called it roast poussin.

Her mother recognised it immediately.

"This is from the supermarket."

Eleanor cut into it carefully.

"The recipe is French."

"The label said reduced."

Richard coughed into his napkin.

The left gate moved slightly in the wind.

Somewhere upstairs, a pipe knocked three times.

Eleanor continued eating.

Halfway through lunch, her brother mentioned selling the house.

The table became quiet.

"Why would we sell?" Eleanor asked.

"The roof needs replacing."

"The roof has character."

"It has daylight."

Eleanor placed her fork down.

“This house is part of who we are.”

Her brother looked at the portrait of Charles Edward.

“We don’t know who any of these people are.”

Eleanor followed his gaze.

“That isn’t the point.”

“What is the point?”

She looked around the table.

The candles.

The gold menus.

The cold soup.

The family wearing coats indoors.

“The point is continuity.”

Richard checked the boiler app under the table.

The repair estimate appeared.

He turned the phone face down.

Dessert arrived.

Eleanor’s mother carried in the supermarket trifle.

She had added fresh strawberries on top.

It looked beautiful.

Everyone relaxed.

For ten minutes, nobody discussed roofs, mortgages or history.

They ate.

They laughed.

Her nephew asked for seconds.

Eleanor watched them.

The room was still cold.

The plates did not match.

One candle had collapsed into its holder.

For a moment, the house looked less like an inheritance and more like a place where people lived.

Then Eleanor's phone vibrated.

The photographer had arrived.

She stood immediately.

"Everyone into the drawing room."

"We have a drawing room?" her sister asked.

"The living room."

They arranged themselves beneath the largest portrait.

Richard stood beside Eleanor.

Her mother held the trifle dish.

Eleanor quietly removed it.

The photographer lifted the camera.

"Closer together."

The family moved.

"Natural smiles."

They tried.

Behind them, Charles Edward watched from a frame purchased for forty dollars.

The photograph was posted that evening.

Black and white.

Soft grain.

No coats.

No supermarket trifle.

No broken gate.

Eleanor wrote:

Some things cannot be bought.

By morning, the post had been shared hundreds of times.

The boiler stopped completely at six fifteen.

Eleanor called the repair company at six twenty.

“The house has been in the family for generations,” Eleanor said.

“And the billing address?”

Eleanor looked towards the gates.

“Fourteen Ashford Street.”

Rich in Free Time

David rarely impressed people on purpose.

He arrived on time.

He wore the same watch for twelve years.

His car made a noise when turning left.

He knew about it.

This separated him from people who called noises “character.”

At work, David left at five.

Not five fifteen.

Not after one last email.

Five.

His manager noticed.

“You heading out?”

“Yes.”

“Big plans?”

“Dinner.”

“With clients?”

“My daughter.”

His manager smiled politely.

David smiled back.

Neither understood the other.

David worked in operations for a company that described itself as fast-moving.

Most days, the company moved in circles.

People spoke about ownership, urgency and bandwidth.

David spoke less.

He finished his work.

Then he left.

His colleague Marcus found this suspicious.

“You’re not worried about visibility?” Marcus asked.

David looked at the ceiling.

“I can see the door.”

“I mean career visibility.”

“I’m visible during work hours.”

Marcus leaned closer.

“That’s not how leadership works.”

David nodded.

Marcus had been waiting six months for a promotion nobody had mentioned.

At lunch, the team discussed holidays.

One colleague had booked a wellness retreat.

Another was flying somewhere with private beaches and public Wi-Fi.

Marcus had upgraded his hotel because the standard room did not reflect where he was in life.

“What about you?” someone asked David.

“We’re going camping.”

There was a pause.

“In a tent?” Marcus asked.

“That’s usually where camping happens.”

“Is it glamping?”

“No.”

“Then what’s the point?”

David thought about this.

“Trees.”

Marcus nodded slowly.

He had no answer prepared for trees.

On Friday, the office held a networking event.

There were drinks, soft lighting and small food arranged on large plates.

David stayed for forty minutes.

Then he put on his coat.

“You’re leaving already?” Marcus asked.

“I said I’d help make pizza.”

“You can make pizza anytime.”

“Not with an eight-year-old.”

Marcus looked toward a group of senior leaders.

“This is where opportunities happen.”

David looked at the same group.

One man was explaining synergy beside a bowl of olives.

“I hope it works out.”

At home, David’s daughter had covered the kitchen counter in flour.

His wife stood beside the oven.

“You’re late,” she said.

“It’s six twelve.”

“You said six.”

“Traffic.”

His daughter looked at him.

“You missed the cheese.”

David removed his jacket.

“That sounds serious.”

“It was.”

They made another pizza.

The first one was shaped like Italy.

The second one was shaped like a country nobody recognised.

David’s daughter called it France.

Nobody corrected her.

Later, they ate on the floor because the dining table was covered in paper, markers and a model volcano.

David’s phone vibrated.

Marcus had posted a photograph from the networking event.

Three executives.

Four champagne glasses.

A caption about proximity and growth.

David liked it.

Then put the phone away.

On Monday, Marcus asked whether David had seen the post.

“Yes.”

“Good room.”

“It looked crowded.”

Marcus laughed.

“You really don’t get it.”

David considered this possible.

That week, the company announced a new leadership program.

Marcus applied immediately.

David did not.

“You should,” Marcus told him.

“Why?”

“It’s a path to senior management.”

“I don’t want senior management.”

Marcus stared at him.

“You can’t say that out loud.”

“Why not?”

“People will think you lack ambition.”

David looked at the calendar on his desk.

Wednesday: school play.

Friday: dinner with his brother.

Saturday: nothing.

He liked Saturday best.

“I have ambition,” he said.

“For what?”

“To have a good week.”

Marcus shook his head.

“That’s not ambition.”

David nodded.

“Then I’m using the wrong word.”

A month later, Marcus got into the leadership program.

He celebrated by cancelling a weekend trip.

“Worth it,” he said.

David congratulated him.

That evening, David’s wife asked whether it bothered him.

“No.”

She waited.

David thought about the title.

The salary.

The small satisfaction of being chosen.

“Not much,” he said.

Marcus began arriving earlier.

Then leaving later.

He bought a new laptop bag.

He started using the phrase “at this level.”

Nobody had told him what level he was at.

One evening, Marcus found David in the parking lot.

David was loading groceries into the noisy car.

“You know what your problem is?” Marcus asked.

David closed the trunk.

“I assume you’re going to tell me.”

“You’re too comfortable.”

David thought about the mortgage.

The car repair.

The school fees.

The camping stove that had broken last summer.

Comfortable was not the word he would have chosen.

Marcus continued.

“You should want more.”

“I do.”

“Like what?”

David leaned against the car.

“More dinners at home.”

Marcus waited.

“More weekends.”

Another pause.

“More time where nobody needs anything from me.”

Marcus smiled.

“That’s not how success works.”

David opened the driver’s door.

“Maybe not.”

The car started on the second attempt.

Marcus watched him drive away.

At eight thirty, David was on the sofa.

His daughter was asleep against his shoulder.

A documentary played quietly.

His wife had fallen asleep too.

The room was untidy.

The car needed servicing.
The camping trip would probably rain.
David looked at the clock.
He had nowhere else to be.
Across town, Marcus was still at the office.
He opened David's social profile.
There were no airport lounges.
No expensive dinners.
No leadership quotes.
Mostly family photographs.
A tent.
A burnt pizza.
A blurry picture of a dog that did not belong to them.
Marcus scrolled back several years.
David looked older.
Then younger.
Then exactly the same.
He always seemed to be somewhere.
Not somewhere important.
Just somewhere he had chosen.
Marcus closed the page.
At ten forty-five, he posted a photograph of the empty office.
The work nobody sees creates the life everyone wants.
The post performed well.
Marcus opened David's profile again.

He stopped at the photograph of the tent.

He began typing.

Does the campsite allow one more?

Marcus looked at the message.

Then deleted it.

The office lights switched off again.